

Oregon - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	National-title caliber; one of the two strongest teams in the preseason model/poll outlook.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 2 (1,597 points; 14 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 2 (+29.2)
Returning production	66% (No. 12) overall · Off. 65% (No. 25) · Def. 66% (No. 12)
Primer power rating	+29.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.2 wins · likely 10-2
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Still elite, with more uncertainty in blocking and specialists than in the championship core.
Confidence	High

2026 identity: Oregon should remain a balanced, efficiency-first contender built around returning QB Dante Moore and a deep skill group, while a veteran defensive front anchors a multiple defense that already excelled at suppressing explosives. The central tension is whether a rebuilt right side/interior of the offensive line and a full specialist reset can avoid becoming the weak links of an otherwise championship roster.

Bottom line: Oregon has top-five caliber at the most important spots and enough continuity to justify a title-level baseline; the main preseason reasons for restraint are OL configuration/availability and the turnover hidden inside an otherwise strong returning-production number.

Beats expectations if: The new OL combination settles without a pass-protection drop, QB Dante Moore turns continuity into another elite passing season, and the secondary led by S Koi Perich and CB Brandon Finney Jr. replaces first-round departures without sacrificing the defense's explosive-play suppression.

Disappoints if: The three unsettled OL spots become a persistent problem, the massive NFL/pro departure class produces more regression than the model expects, and the new specialist operation costs field position or close games.

Five things to remember

- 1 ★ **QB Dante Moore:** QB Dante Moore is a settled returning QB1 and an AP first-team preseason selection; Oregon does not enter 2026 with quarterback ambiguity.
- 2 **National baseline:** SP+ ranks Oregon No. 2 overall with the No. 1 offense and No. 2 defense; the AP preseason poll also ranks the Ducks No. 2.
- 3 **NFL departures:** The defensive front keeps OLB/DE Matayo Uiagalelei, DL A'Mauri Washington and multiple other veterans, giving Oregon unusual continuity despite seven NFL draft departures elsewhere.
- 4 **OL questions:** LT Fox Crader and C Iapani Laloulu are the stable OL pieces; LG/RG/RT remain unsettled, but returning starter OL Dave Luli has returned to on-field work and is expected to be available for the opener.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** The schedule is 8/10 by the SOS rule (SP+ SOS No. 21), with the Nov. 7 trip to Ohio State the clearest true swing game for a team projected around 10 wins.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	13-2 (8-2 Big Ten)	● Excellent
Scoring	36.9 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	452.2 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	198.6 YPG · 5.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	8.70 YPA · 31 TD / 10 INT	● Elite
Third downs	46.8%	● Very good
Scoring defense	17.9 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	273.7 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	115.7 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	157.9 YPG · 5.59 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Elite

Oregon was already elite by conventional measures: scoring offense No. 10, total offense No. 16, rush offense No. 20, pass efficiency No. 7 and third downs No. 19; the defense was No. 12 in scoring, No. 7 in total defense and No. 8 in pass-efficiency defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+9.21 · No. 11	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.241 · No. 6	● Elite
Off. success rate	51.4% · No. 5	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	15.0% · No. 14	● Elite
Havoc allowed	10.6% · No. 5	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+9.82 · No. 8	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.200 · No. 5	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	36.0% · No. 14	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	6.7% · No. 2	● Elite
Havoc created	18.8% · No. 12	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Oregon was elite on both sides in 2025, with top-tier efficiency and explosive-play prevention. The 2026 question is replacement continuity rather than whether the underlying baseline was real.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	● Dan Lanning - returning	● ↔ Continuity preserves the existing program structure.
OC / play-caller	◆ Drew Mehringer - internal promotion from co-OC/TE; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Internal promotion keeps the offensive terminology intact while moving Drew Mehringer into primary play-calling responsibility.
DC / play-caller	◆ Chris Hampton - internal promotion from co-DC/secondary; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Internal promotion preserves defensive continuity while Chris Hampton takes primary game-day calling responsibility.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Iverson Hooks	UAB	● ↔ Major-rotation receiver with Biletnikoff watchlist recognition, but he joins a deep room rather than filling a proven No. 1 vacancy.
◆ OL Michael Bennett III	Yale	● ↔ Material first-unit RG/RT candidate in the unsettled OL mix; projection risk remains.

Out	To	Loss
TE Kenyon Sadiq	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 1, No. 16	● ↓ First-round loss of the 2025 starting/record-setting tight end.
OL Emmanuel Pregon	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 3, No. 88	● ↓ Fifteen-game starting guard leaves a major continuity hole.
OT Alex Harkey	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 6, No. 206	● ↓ Fourteen-start right tackle departs.
OT Isaiah World	NFL (L.A. Chargers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Another fourteen-start left tackle departs, compounding the OL rebuild.
WR Malik Benson	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 6, No. 195	● ↓ 2025 team leader in receptions/yards/receiving TD and a punt-return contributor leaves.
RB Noah Whittington	NFL (Houston), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 2025 leading rusher (829 yards, six TD) departs.

Offense net: Elite in absolute terms but lower continuity at OL/TE/RB/WR than the overall returning-production figure suggests. ● ↔

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ S Koi Perich	Minnesota	● ↑ First-unit safety with AP first-team and major national watchlist recognition; the strongest incoming defensive upgrade.
◆ NB Carl Williams IV	Baylor	● ↔ Projects first at nickel and fills an immediate secondary role, but does not carry a proven elite-production profile.

Out	To	Loss
S Dillon Thieneman	NFL (Chicago), Round 1, No. 25	● ↓ First-round departure after 96 tackles; major back-end continuity loss.
LB Bryce Boettcher	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 4, No. 135	● ↓ Team/Big Ten-leading 136 tackles leave the middle of the defense.
DB Jadon Canady	NFL (Kansas City), Round 4, No. 109	● ↓ Thirteen-start defensive back leaves another high-snap vacancy.

Defense net: Still top-tier because the veteran front survives and the secondary reload is unusually talented, but LB/safety continuity is meaningfully lower. ● ↔

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Multiple/spread-option supporting structure with an explicit 2026 emphasis on balancing complexity against execution; established QB play allows Oregon to threaten both efficiently and explosively.	QB Dante Moore plus a deep WR/TE group, with a 2025 offense that finished No. 6 in EPA/play and No. 5 in success rate.	Pass protection and run-game consistency while the unsettled LG/RG/RT combination settles; Dave Iuli is expected back for the opener.
Defense	Multiple 3-4 supporting label with Hampton describing a broad menu that is narrowed through self-scout to what the personnel executes best.	Veteran front quality and elite explosive-play prevention; 2025 defensive EPA/play allowed ranked No. 5 and explosive rate allowed No. 2.	Replacing LB Bryce Boettcher, S Dillon Thieneman and DB Jadon Canady without losing communication/tackling stability behind the front.
Special teams	Complete specialist transition with transfer competition/role projection at K, P and LS.	P Bailey Ettridge and LS RJ Todd are consistently projected first at their positions.	Kicker remains unsettled and all three primary 2025 specialists are gone.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A	● ↔	High	QB Dante Moore returns as the settled starter after directing the SP+ No. 1 offense.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	RB Jordon Davison leads a deep rotation after RB Noah Whittington departs.
WR	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	WR Evan Stewart returns to a talented room replacing WR Malik Benson and other volume.
TE	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	TE Jamari Johnson returns after 32 catches and must absorb more work after TE Kenyon Sadiq departs.
OL	● B+	● ↓	Medium-low	C Iapani Laloulou anchors a line replacing multiple NFL-bound starters with several spots unsettled.
DL/Edge	● A	● ↔	High	A veteran front led by returning DL A’Mauri Washington gives the defense its safest strength.
LB	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	LB Devon Jackson and LB Jerry Mixon lead a talented group replacing LB Bryce Boettcher.
Secondary	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	S Koi Perich headlines a high-end reload after S Dillon Thieneman and DB Jadon Canady depart.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	Kicker, punter and long snapper all reset, creating more uncertainty than elsewhere on the roster.
Coaching	● A	● ↔	High	HC Dan Lanning and his coordinator structure provide strong continuity and role clarity.
Overall	● A+	● ↔	High	National-title caliber; one of the two strongest teams in the preseason model/poll outlook.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Dante Moore	QB	● National star / top-tier returning quarterback	AP 1st · Big Ten preseason honoree · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Settled returning QB1 on the SP+ No. 1 offense; the single most important source of Oregon’s evaluation stability.
★ ◆ Koi Perich (TR: Minnesota)	S	● National star / immediate-impact secondary addition	AP 1st · Big Ten preseason honoree · Bronko Nagurski · Jim Thorpe · Paul Hornung	Projects first at safety and is the clearest talent answer to a secondary that lost Dillon Thieneman and Jadon Canady.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Brandon Finney Jr.	CB	● National-level corner	AP 2nd · Walter Camp 1st · Bednarik · Bronko Nagurski · Jim Thorpe	High-confidence projected first-unit corner in a reloaded secondary.
A'Mauri Washington	DL	● National-level interior anchor	AP 1st · Walter Camp 2nd · Bednarik · Outland	Returning first-unit interior piece in the veteran front that gives the defense its safest strength.
Matayo Uiagalelei	OLB/D E	● High-end national edge	Bednarik	Returning first-unit edge and one of the front's main disruption pieces.
Iapani Laloulu	C	● High-end national center	Outland · Rimington	The settled center is the critical continuity point for an OL replacing multiple NFL-bound starters.
Jamari Johnson	TE	● High-end conference starter	Walter Camp 2nd · Biletnikoff · John Mackey	Returns after 32 catches/510 yards/three TD and must absorb a larger role after Kenyon Sadiq's first-round departure.
Evan Stewart	WR	● High-upside veteran return	-	Back after missing 2025 and projected first unit; his availability adds proven veteran talent to a room replacing Malik Benson.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Challenging but title-compatible; Oregon will be favored in most games, with a small number of true tests.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 21
Hardest stretch	at Ohio State → Michigan → at Michigan State → Washington
Swing games	at Ohio State
Advantage	Bye on Oct. 3 after the road trip to USC; Michigan and Washington come at home.
Expected	10.2 wins · likely 10-2
Floor / ceiling	9-3 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Likely to be priced as an elite favorite almost every week; the useful angle is identifying when OL/specialist uncertainty is over- or under-discounted rather than blindly backing a top-two team.
Back them when	The matchup does not heavily stress the unsettled OL and the price still leaves room for Oregon's large efficiency/defensive-front edge.
Fade/pass when	The market prices Oregon near a flawless-title-team ceiling against opponents capable of forcing obvious passing downs or exploiting specialist volatility.
Key monitor	Final OL five and Dave Iuli's return to full-game workload, kicker winner, health/availability of QB Dante Moore and veteran defensive-front anchors
Week 1 baseline	Oregon -26.0 · rating-only baseline; Oregon primer +29.0 minus Boise State SP+ proxy +5.1 plus 2.0 default home field = 25.9 points; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Oregon -24.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Oregon remains a title-caliber team because QB Dante Moore returns behind an elite 2025 efficiency profile and a veteran defensive front. The roster still has top-end answers at receiver, running back and throughout the defense despite a large professional departure class.

The uncertainty is concentrated at OL, linebacker/secondary continuity and a rebuilt specialist operation. The schedule is demanding but compatible with contention; whether the new line protects QB Dante Moore against the best opponents is the

cleanest diagnostic for Oregon's ceiling.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [scheme](#) · [departures](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#) · [team source 3](#) · [luli availability update](#)

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